winning in UP without the support of a community that makes up 19.2 per cent of the state's population (higher than the national average of 14.2 per cent[1])? 'Look, now the times have changed,' he replied. 'When you came, you saw so many famous maulanas, national-level maulanas, sitting with me. Three more are coming in a while to meet me. They are international-level maulanas. In one section of Muslims, the thinking has changed—I won't say for the whole section—and this was a reason to worry for the Opposition. It was scared that Muslims also should not go with BJP, so they started false campaigning on the CAA, especially with Muslims, and created a conspiracy to create misunderstandings. This is because a section of Muslims, especially educated Muslims, are getting attracted to the BJP.'[2] We ran out of time as he finished, and another group of maulanas entered his office, this time accompanied by leaders from the BJP's local Minority Cell, which coordinates the party's work with minority religions.

It was evident that Sharma was very pleased by the visits of these Muslim leaders. However, his response to the Muslim question needs to be read in conjunction with his unequivocal emphasis on what he considered the primary reason for the BJP's electoral successes: its core ideology. 'The fundamental reason for BJP's victory is that we didn't change our set guiding principles,' he insisted . 'When we lost, we still remained steadfast on our guiding principles. When we won, then also we remained steadfast in our policies. We didn't do the politics of loss and profit … BJP's agenda remained the same as it was before through our manifesto: to remove Article 370, Triple Talaq, CAA, the construction of the Ram Temple. These four–five issues were there, and with them, nationalism as a centre-point. This has a direct impact on the people.'[3] Ever since the BJP's rise to power, this emphasis on its core ideology has been the primary fault line in the ideological debate between its supporters and those who oppose it. The party's critics have argued that its ascendance has raised serious questions about the fate of Indian secularism,[4] signalled the rise of a new kind of 'toxic majoritarianism'[5] and resulted in the gutting of Indian democracy to reduce Muslims to second-class status.